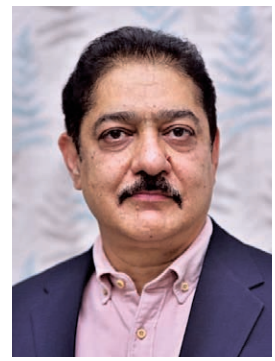
Secretary for Tourism & Information Technology, Government of Goa
SANJEEV AHUJA, IAS

What infrastructural developments do you seek to achieve in the tourism industry?

There is a great focus on tourism infrastructure development, both through central and state government funding. We have proposed four new projects to obtain Central funds under the Swadesh Darshan 2.0 scheme.



The projects in north Goa will be focused on the development of Mayem lake, Harvalem, Bondla zoo and nearby areas. The second project will be focussed on developing the areas adjacent to Porvorim, the bird sanctuary, the hinterland and the adjoining areas of Porvorim. We have also proposed the development of Colva beach with a massive infrastructure push, creating basic amenities and the development of Canacona taluka. The focus is on tourism infrastructural development. The state government is looking forward to increasing its budget to create basic amenities such as washrooms, changing rooms, CCTV cameras, safety and seating arrangements for tourists across the state.

Your focus is on boosting eco-tourism and rural tourism in Goa besides concentrating on wellness, adventure and spiritualism. Please share your plans.

There is certainly a great potential to encourage eco and rural tourism. Goa is blessed with natural beauty and more than 50 per cent green cover, making it a natural spot for eco-tourism. Rural tourism also holds a great potential because we have beautiful hinterland villages, and stakeholders are also willing to receive basic training and set up bed and breakfast units and Airbnb units in their own villages. This will lead to the spread of tourism across the state and employment opportunities in newer areas.

We are doing very well in wellness and adventure tourism. In fact, a few years ago, Goa won the national tourism award for the best state for adventure tourism. We have several well-known wellness brands in Goa. The coastal state is also a leading place for seeking various wellness and relaxation therapies.

Goa also attracts many spiritual tourists. We have the churches of Old Goa, which are UNESCO World Heritage monuments that attract tourists from all over the world. In 2024, we are having the decennial exposition of the relics of St Francis Xavier, when tourists from all over the world will converge in large numbers.

The temple town of Ponda is famous for its temples such as Ramnathi, Mangueshi, Shantadurga and Nageshi, which are frequented by many pilgrims from Maharashtra, Karnataka and far-flung places of the country.

Spiritual tourism holds a great potential as 70 per cent of people in India travel for pilgrimages and the like. There is a big share of tourism that is waiting to be explored and we will explore opportunities in that direction.

Director of Tourism, Government of Goa
NIKHIL DESAI, IAS

How will the concept 'Rediscover Goa' boost tourism and contribute to Goa's employment sector? What experience do you intend to offer travellers?

Goa is changing its branding and destination management. There are several facets in the state which we need to explore and promote - for example hinterland tourism, the beautiful forests of Goa, its wildlife, eco-tourism, bird life. They are all amazing concepts.



Goa is also cementing its place as a leading place for adventure tourism. We are leaders in nightlife, as well as a wedding destination but there are several other areas, which need focus and the government is doing all it can to rediscover lesser-known spots - beautiful forts, rivers, the hinterlands, trekking circuits, waterfalls. All our efforts will be directed at taking tourists to newer places, especially in the virgin talukas of Canacona, Pernem and Satari. But we will be mindful of the fact that it shouldn't lead to overcrowding and mass tourism. Instead, we should encourage tourists to come and enjoy these places responsibly.

We have decided to tie up with Airbnb and through them showcase various facets of Goa's unique art, culture and heritage and the various options that the tourist can explore.

You have amended the Coastal Zone Regulation Notification 2011 with regards to setting up permanent beach structures. Why?

The government has proposed certain amendments to the CRZ notification. Goa was one of the first states to have special provision for temporary beach shacks or seasonal structures. These shacks could help a lot of unemployed youth to find employment opportunities. There is also a proposal to allow local communities to use their homes for tourism - to set up restaurants and offer rooms for bed and breakfast facilities for which an amendment is required. The government has taken up the issue with the Ministry of Environment and Forest.

How will the new tourism services help bring in luxury tourists?

The quality of tourists is also very important and Goa Tourism is making all efforts to introduce quality tourism opportunities in the state such as high-end weddings, luxury yachts, golf courses, nautical tourism and MICE. We are also looking for high-end shopping options. Goa has become a leading destination for cuisine and food tourism. This year more than 40 cruise vessels are expected to dock at MPT harbor and we are going to further improve the infrastructural facilities all over the state.